The generalized external architecture of the data product is shown in figure 5.11.

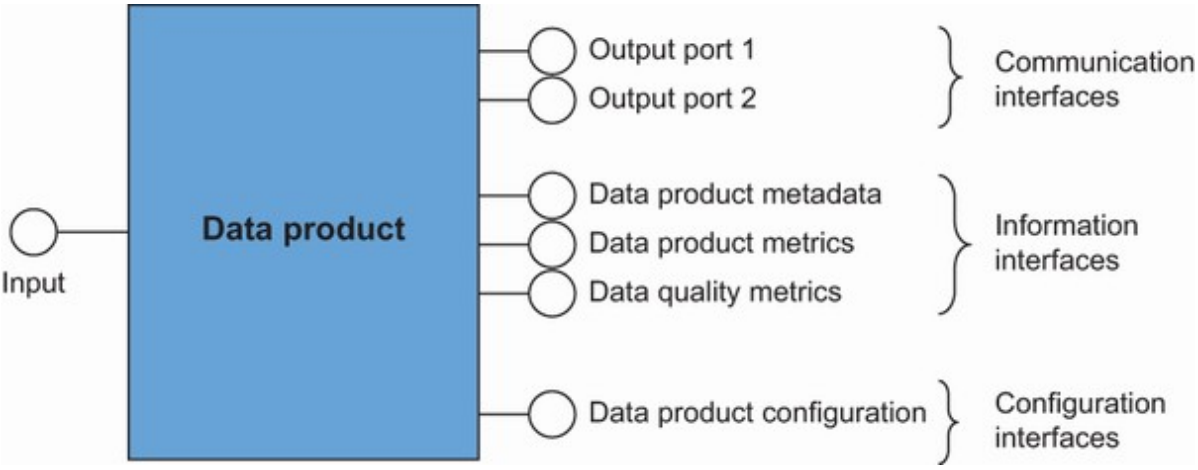


Figure 5.11 The main groups of interfaces of a data product

We can divide all of the data product interfaces into three main groups:

- *Communication interfaces*—Input interfaces and output ports, which define the format and protocol in which data can be read (e.g., files, API, database, and stream)
- *Information interfaces*—Interfaces that can be used by users to monitor and retrieve additional information such as metadata, lineage, current metrics, or quality indicators
- *Configuration interfaces*—Interfaces, mainly platform specific, that enable the data product to be included in the data mesh ecosystem (e.g., security options and parameters, data sharing agreement statements)

Specifically, the self-serve platform uses configuration and information interfaces to configure, catalog, monitor, and visualize the relationships between data products. Interfaces must be standardized for the interoperability to be possible. This standardization is part of computational governance, which is described in more detail in later chapters.

In the next subsection, we will take a closer look at external ports, which are the data product's primary means of exposing data.